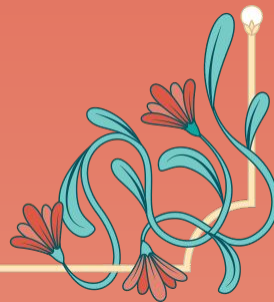
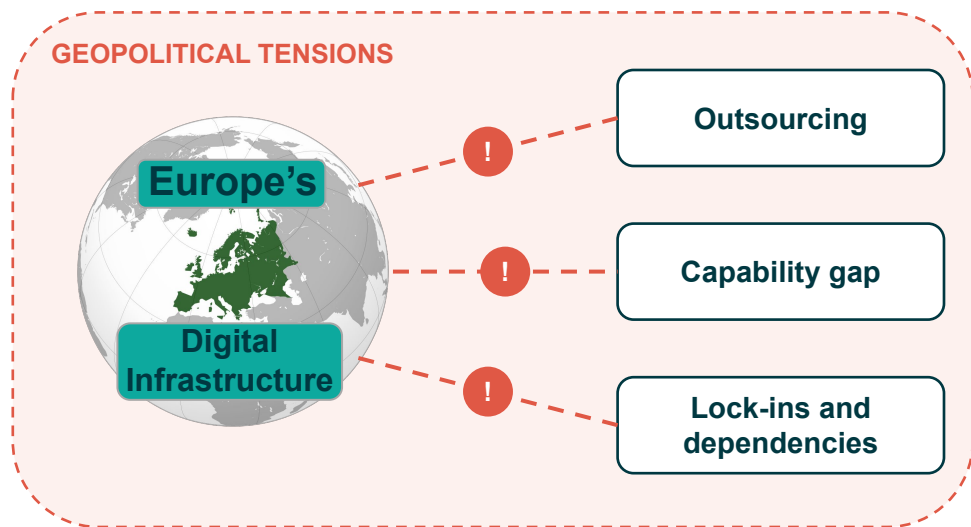


Open Source At The Crossroads And The Fight To Stay Open

Johan Linåker and Nithya Ruff



The Geopolitical Backdrop We Live In Today

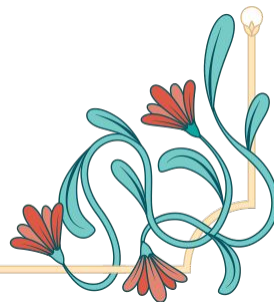


From dependency to risk

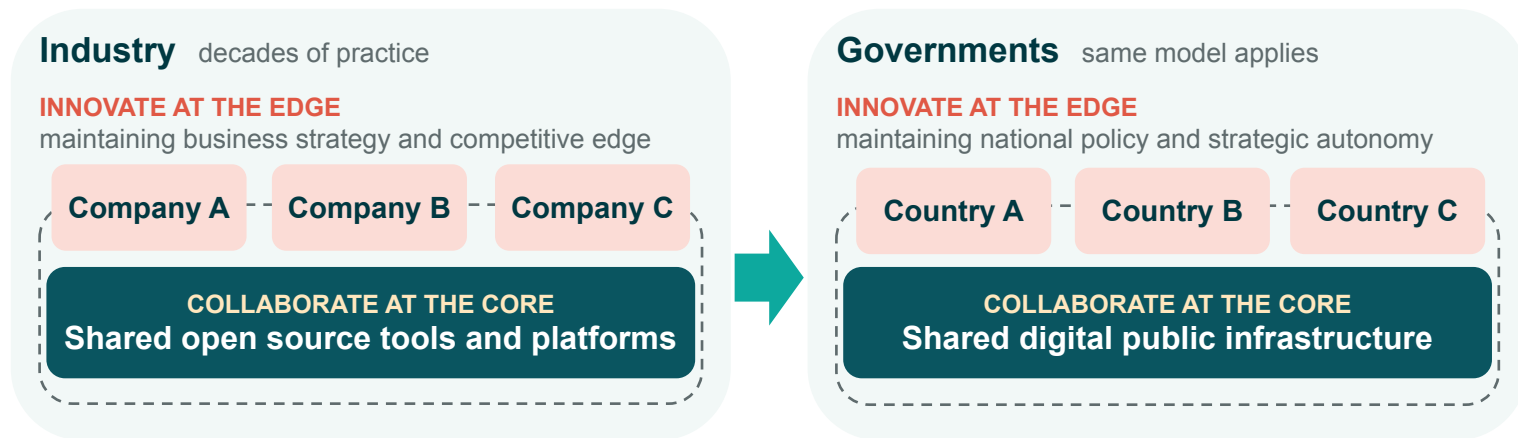
- 1 **Outsourcing** led to capability gap, lock-ins and structural dependencies
- 2 **Tensions** turn dependencies into risks to autonomy and resilience
- 3 **Governments** are waking up, at different speeds, to regain control

Open source now a strategic pillar in National and European tech policy

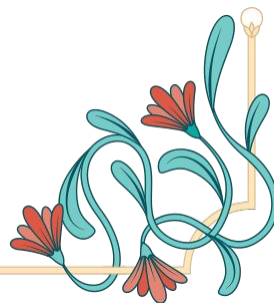
Europe in focus, yet sovereignty is a universal concern: the same questions apply in countries such as Canada, Trinidad and Tobago, and Sierra Leone, as well as regions such as Eastern Africa, South-East Asia and Latin America.



Balancing Sovereignty With Global Collaboration



Rivalry is no showstopper. Competitors share open source cores and compete on top; geopolitical rivals can do the same. Autonomy and influence, as well as robustness and security still requires effort and investment.



Choose where to collaborate, invest and control

Sovereignty is a set of decisions, made layer by layer

COLLABORATE

Shared foundations

Governments care about

- Cost and speed
- Securing code everyone runs
- Interoperability across borders

OS, cloud native, AI frameworks, security tooling

INVEST AND LEAD

Strategic edge

Governments care about

- Language and culture
- Citizen services
- Local jobs and economic growth

Local language AI, digital public infrastructure (X-Road, MOSIP)

CONTROL

Mission critical

Governments care about

- National security and defence
- Critical infrastructure resilience
- Data residency and privacy

Defence systems, classified data, sensitive citizen records

WHY COLLABORATE AT ALL?



Influence standards



Shared security



Cost and speed



No lock-in



Local talent



Industry already learnt this lesson

Rivals stopped duplicating the core and started building it together

1990s

Compete alone

Each vendor builds its own OS and stack
The Unix wars

2000s

Collaborate on the core

Competitors co-develop shared foundations
Linux, Apache

2010s

Build OSPOs

Policy, compliance and real community engagement
TODO Group

2015+

Open source their own code

Release projects to set standards and fill gaps
Kubernetes, PyTorch

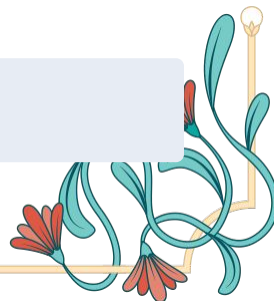
TODAY

Co-invest in shared challenges

Security, AI and more, funded together
OpenSSF, Alpha-Omega, Agentic AI Foundation



Competitors learnt to share the core two decades ago. Governments can too, and keep their sovereignty.



Lessons Learned From Industry

Industry

Decades of learning to collaborate on software

Governments

Forerunners

Most just
begun

Need to Leapfrog

1960s–70s

Today

Now: geopolitics makes sovereignty, resilience and cyber security top policy questions

What has held governments back

Outsourcing

Risk-averse procurement

Comfort culture

Lack of political buy-in

Limited understanding

Enablers for the leap

OSPOs

Drives organisational change

Regulations (e.g., CRA)

Distributes responsibility to market

Internal engineering houses

Grows technical capability

Funding schemes

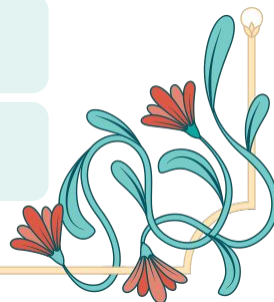
Enables maintainer support

Vendor ecosystems

Provides service and maintenance

Public procurement

Enables demand-side push

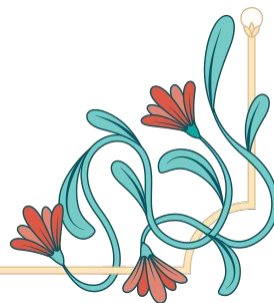


The Role And Need Of Stewards



Often rebuilt as parallel stacks, country by country, region by region

What sets public sector open source apart



New Forms of Public Stewardship

New,
complementary
public-sector
stewards

National & Municipal

E.g., OS2 (DK) · Adullact (FR) · IMio (BE)
· Open Cities (CZ) · Sambruk (SE) ·
PagoPa (IT) · ZenDiS (DE)

Supranational & Cross-border

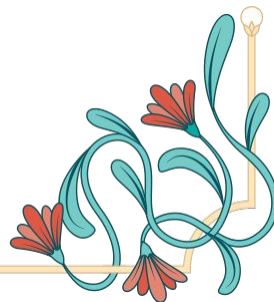
E.g., Digital Commons EDIC · Proposed
European DPI steward · NIIS (X-Road) ·
Consul Democracy Foundation (Consul)

Core & Horizontal Infrastructure

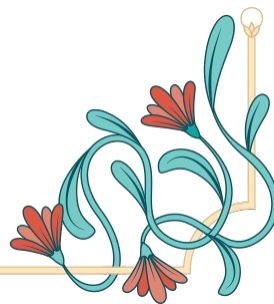
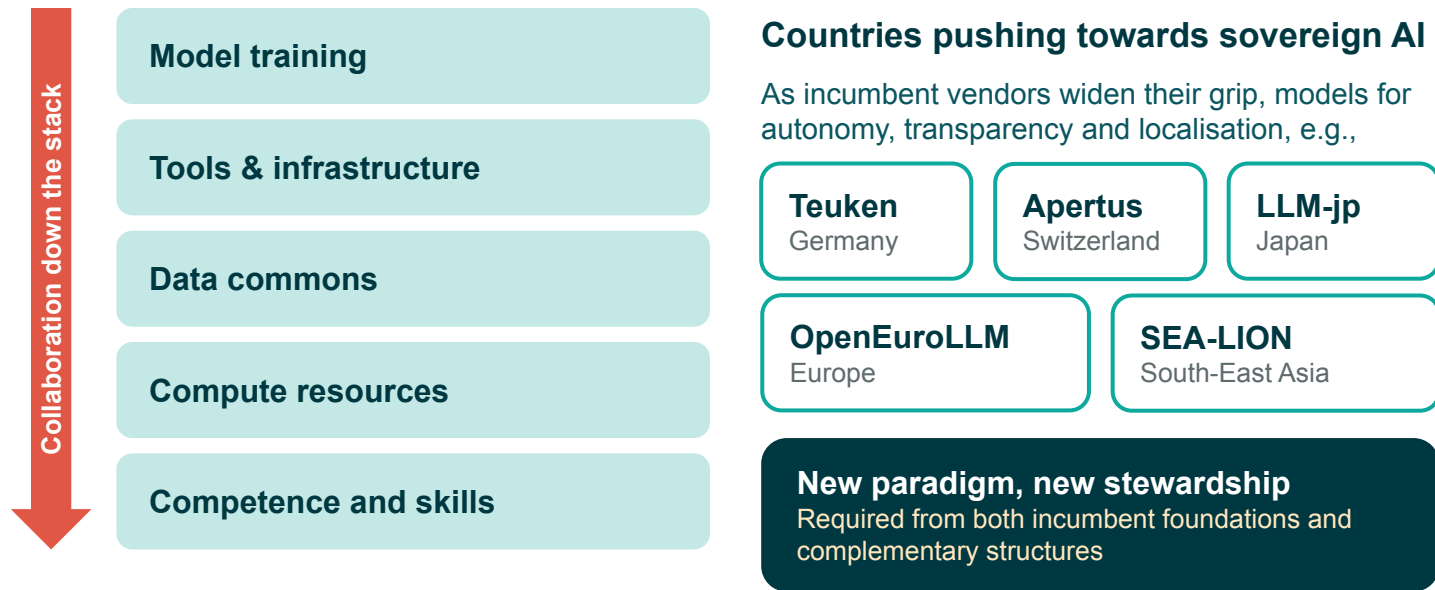
Incumbent foundations and
stewardship models

Higher up the stack: narrower use cases shaped by local regulation, language, norms and culture

Widen the ecosystem: bring public stewards into forums like the Open Source Congress. Develop shared practice as called for by the EU Open Source strategy.



AI: Widening Open Innovation Beyond a Single Project



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